

Meeting Minutes

HRRP PO Forum

Date: 26 05 2016

Time: 2:00-4:30 p.m.

Location: DUDBC Hall, Babarmahal

Focal Point: Arshad Rashid/ Jennifer Duyne

Participants Organizations:

UN Habitat, Lumanti, Helvetas, A & D, ASF Nepal, World Renew, Minergy Initiatives, British RC, ACTED, JICA, Bungamati Reconstruction Committee, NSET, LSE, Habitat for Humanity Nepal, ASF UK, UNRCO, All Hands Volunteers, Sankhu Reconstruction Committee, SDC, HRRP

Agendas

1. **Welcome Note by Arshad Rashid, HRRP**
2. **Basic principles of Community Driven reconstruction by Jennifer Duyne, HRRP**
3. **Community's Reconstruction Visions and Plans in Sankhu by Suresh Pradhan, Sankhu Reconstruction Committee**
4. **Building settlements with communities in Machhegaun and Thecho by Lumanti**
5. **Rebuilding Bungamati, by Prem Bhakta Maharjan, Bungamati Reconstruction Committee**
6. **Comments and ways to move forward, by Lajana Manandhar, Lumanti**
7. **Discussion, moderated by Jennifer Duyne, HRRP**

1. Welcome Note by Arshad Rashid, HRRP

Arshad Rashid welcome the participants and stated that the purpose of the meeting was to emphasize the importance of community participation in reconstruction, particularly in focus to urban reconstruction and reconstruction of historical settlements.

2. Basic principles of Community Driven reconstruction by Jennifer Duyne, HRRP

Jennifer Duyne (Technical Team Leader, HRRP) drew the attention that the urban areas are also badly affected by the Earthquake (EQ), and there is a desperate need for reconstructing urban areas as well. She introduced the community based organizations (CBOs) that have come forward for reconstruction in urban areas, with their own ideas and vision.

She urged Partner Organizations (POs) to incorporate local initiatives, make best use of local capacities and support the visions of local community based organizations in the reconstruction process.

She shared some of her thoughts on community based reconstruction, extracted from a chapter of a book that she wrote earlier named "Safer Home, Stronger Communities".

The book comprises frameworks in moving forward on community-led reconstruction process. It highly emphasizes the direct involvement of the affected people throughout the process of reconstruction cycle i.e. during the assessment, planning and designing, implementation, monitoring and evaluation, for the effectiveness and sustainability of the process.

She put her view that the local government should support the community driven reconstruction approach by coordinating with the communities and the POs involved, and help to preserve the unique identity of communities.

She concluded that communities should have decision-making power over planning and organizational management. The agencies should support the local initiatives whereas the government should guide and support the overall reconstruction process. She accredited that homework needs to be done to establish the institutional framework so as to execute locally-led rebuilding process, legitimizing the process.

3. Community's Reconstruction Visions and Plans in Sankhu by Suresh Pradhan, Sankhu Reconstruction Committee

Suresh Pradhan from Sankhu Reconstruction Committee (SRC), Sankhu, gave a presentation emphasizing the need to preserve historical and traditional settlements such as Sankhu.

He mentioned that Sankhu is a unique settlement, which dates back to 3,300 years and is rich in history and culture. The devastating EQ of April 25, 2015 completely destroyed two-third of the total houses (800 of 1,200), most of the heritage monuments, public places, and dried the water sources. It has led to out-migration and extra vulnerability among its residents. 300 of 800 damaged houses are extremely vulnerable, and are in need of urgent attention from government and international partners.

He emphasized on the need to rebuild Sankhu as a trade center as its old times, acknowledging the potential trade market of Sankhu and also envisioned developing heritage based tourism infrastructure and services.

He shared the challenges that being a newly formed municipality, Sankhu has little vision and capacity, which has led to sluggish pace of urban planning (lack of institutional capacity). He stressed that it is time to invest in public infrastructures like road, water supply and sewage system as it is necessary to build these before the rebuilding of houses. He further explained that even though the SRC has vision of favorable reconstruction, it lacks the financial resources to carry it out.

He emphasized that instant need of EQ survivors cannot await and it's the rights of people to get assistance, especially the vulnerable ones. He stressed the urgent need to have a contingency plan so the reconstruction could move ahead. He put forward his view that they (the CBO's) like to lead the process of reconstruction from community initiatives, and requested the government and the partners to contribute preserving the identity of Sankhu collectively.

4. Building settlements with communities in Machhegaun and Thecho by Lumanti

Members of Lumanti shared community led reconstruction practices in Machhegaun and Thecho. It was informed that the main objective of Lumanti is to build a better and

sustainable community through collective approach for entire settlement. It was also informed that the community together will do the reconstruction in the areas covered by Lumanti for grant distribution, even though the grant will be disbursed in the individual basis.

They detailed that they have been providing support to the affected families through women groups and have already built 6000 temporary shelters in Kathmandu, Rasuwa and Dhading, and further plans working in Kathmandu, Lalitpur, Rasuwa and Makwanpur. Lumanti shared that they would be facilitating the reconstruction process led by the CBOs. They had their view that if the houses are built on individual basis, it will lose its identity and traditional values. If built in collective approach, it would contribute in establishing guidelines, norms and regulation for managing the settlement and protecting its traditional values. It was agreed that women in the community will be managing financial part of the reconstruction through women cooperative groups. Through the community mapping process, cluster community of 20-25 houses will be responsible for reconstruction of the respective community, and Lumanti will facilitate technical and financial assistance. Through the means of participatory identification of issue and planning, these cluster will help in identifying the vulnerable groups.

One of the key challenges identified was that 20-40% of the households in community do not have land ownership certificates, and huge number of house are below the standard plot size, restricting to the building permit process. Also, the community have raised their concern to provide subsidy to build the traditional houses, as it requires additional cost.

Lumanti informed that they are planning to form a guideline on community-driven reconstruction and recovery through the engagement of community members, stakeholders, government authorities and POs. Such guideline will also help in facilitating other settlements in the reconstruction process.

5. Rebuilding Bungamati, by Prem Bhakta Maharjan, Bungamati Reconstruction Committee

Prem Bhakta Maharjan gave a presentation highlighting the importance to build Bungamati as an example of tourist destination. According to him, Bungamati used to be one of the popular tourists attractions prior to EQ, accounting to more than 1000 tourist visits per month averagely. He explained that Bungamati has a great potential in tourism development if the traditional heritage settlements and local culture and traditions are preserved. He informed that 'Temporary Shelter and Rehabilitation Committee' in Bungamati is formed to distribute the relief materials and facilitate the reconstruction activities. Sub-committees such as Technical Committee, Land Rental Committee, Archaeology Inventory Committee, Public Relation Committee and Debris Removal Committee are also established. The Committee plans to rebuild Bungamati as an example of ancient culturally-rich settlement by building 500 houses in similar modality, taking the reconstruction process as an opportunity for tourism attraction, retaining traditional heritage values.

He informed the formation of 'Bungamati Area Reconstruction and Development Council' (in the process of registration at CDO, Lalitpur) is to simplify the community participation in rebuilding process, by keeping the local people at the center of reconstruction process. The

Council visions rebuilding Bungamati in 5 years' time frame. They have prepared Bungamati Charter (which is under consultation) as a guideline for reconstruction. He stated that it is not possible to construct individual houses in the core settlement areas in accordance to the recently announced building bylaws, and thus consultations are going with high level authorities to explore alternatives. He further added that NPR 200,000 grant amount for reconstruction of houses is not enough as it is much costlier to reconstruct the traditional houses. He put forward the view that the community should be provided considerable amount of soft loan for the reconstruction both to be complied and traditionally preserved.

6. Comments and ways to move forward, by Lajana Manandhar, Lumanti

Lajana Manandhar from Lumanti stated that they want to reach to a wider audiences, encouraging them to be a part of urban reconstruction. For the purpose, a different workshop was arranged in the following day, in consultation with NRA expert on urban heritage. They have also submitted the recommendations of the previous workshop to the NRA. The whole purpose is to engage and sensitize the government in ongoing activities and the further action required.

She reiterated that only few settlements in the urban areas have started the reconstruction process, and majority of them still lacks any vision on how to move forward. These communities need technical assistance to facilitate reconstruction process, as well as strong advocacy to the government and other stakeholders. Organizations need to be better organized and coordinated, which would be lessons learnt for community-driven reconstruction elsewhere.

She stressed that community led reconstruction is particularly crucial in heritage settlements. She summarized that enough space and flexibility should be embedded in the policy guidelines by government to allow sustainable community-driven process.

She closed her remarks citing a phrase that , “relying on outsider is not possible all the time as they can give one-off support only but the neighbors will give life time support”.

7. Discussion, moderated by Jennifer Duyne, HRRP

British Red Cross raised questions on how was vulnerability being addressed in the presented cases.

Lumanti replied that community members were setting the vulnerable criteria themselves through community mapping which allowed them to trace the vulnerable families that needs extra support. Moreover, the community of Macchegaun and Thecho also came up with ideas on how the vulnerable families could be supported.

SRC added that every single households in the peri-urban areas are somehow vulnerable as people have tried to reconstruct their houses by selling their assets such as land in the past year. According to him every households that had to resort to these coping mechanism fall under being vulnerable.

SRC mentioned that vulnerability also lies in terms of cultural identity restoration. SRC added that those households who had taken loan prior to EQ, are not eligible to take loan

again, directly pushing them into vulnerability. Also, the system denotes people not having enough collateral cannot take the loan, when in reality these are the most vulnerable ones. He urged POs to raise these issues to the government.

NSET responded that although the priority is reconstruction of private houses, but at the same time sustainable development of the municipality should be planned to effectively regulate development. He had his view that community cannot work individually, so has to function in coordination with government bodies. He added that communities have to be unified and organized first to advocate to the government and political leaders, to allocate sufficient fund. NSET suggested the CBOs to work with respective municipality and form reconstruction plan accordingly.

JICA drew from previous experience in 2008 EQ (Sichuan, China) and recommended the strategy to advertise and build back these peri-urban areas as tourist attraction. He added that if a community envisions to rebuild and develop this way, then code-complied buildings and refined community infrastructure (proper sewage water management, proper toilet and sanitation facilities) are to be ensured and put in place. He also shared the observation that during many self-initiative reconstruction in urban areas, the quality of building materials (cements, bricks) is defective, which leads to huge potential risks and should be addressed.

UN Habitat highlighted that the purpose of the meeting was to help all the 52 settlements in Kathmandu valley alike Sankhu or Bungamati that have been damaged. The initiatives for reconstruction has started only in very few settlements and thus the system is vulnerable and will be more if it moves in a very slow place as of now. He urged interested POs in mapping the 52 settlements, regarding its situation and the activities taking place. He was optimistic that Bungamati coming out with a charter could be a reference for all other settlements.

HRRP acknowledged the issue of lack of presence of partners in the urban areas right from the starting phase of reconstruction and encouraged POs for more initiatives and efforts to work in urban reconstruction.

It was agreed on that a guideline for community driven recovery and reconstruction in urban areas needs to be developed soon and submitted to the government, before any guidelines come from the government.

Action Points

1. Community based Organizations working in urban reconstruction to expedite the guidelines making procedure and submit to the NRA, along with the recommendations, before the government comes up with the guidelines.

Next Meeting

The next HRRP PO Forum meeting will be held on 24 June 2016 from 2:00 p.m. in DUDCC Hall, Babarmahal led by HRRP, can be contacted by Arshad Rashid / Jennifer Duyne

Meeting Participants List/Attendance Sheet

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